

Session 1: Philosopher, Teacher, Prophet, Sage

Key Takeaways

- Early audiences of Jesus' teaching in Matthew's gospel saw Jesus as participating in the tradition of ancient philosophical thinkers, who taught and embodied the good life.
- In his teachings, Jesus relies especially on the thought categories of the Hebrew Bible: Torah, prophecy, and wisdom.
- Jesus presents himself and his teachings as a fulfillment of and a step forward in the story of God and Israel.

Jesus Among the Philosophers

In the Gospel of Matthew, Jesus is presented as a great philosopher in the ancient sense, a true lover of wisdom who both teaches and embodies the way to the good life (adapted from Jonathan Pennington, [Jesus the Great Philosopher](#) and Robert Kinney, [Hellenistic Dimensions of the Gospel of Matthew](#)).

In the 3rd century Greco-Roman city of Dura-Europos, there was a Jewish synagogue and a Christian house church located near each other. Both structures have beautifully preserved mosaic paintings of stories from the Hebrew Bible and New Testament. There is a fascinating parallel between the synagogue's depiction of Moses and the burning bush and the church's portrait of Jesus healing the paralyzed man (below). Both are portrayed with the dress of ancient Greek philosophers (Greek toga, arm raised, teaching).



Crispian, Crispins (2023). [Wikimedia Commons](#).



Yale University Art Gallery (2019). [Wikimedia Commons](#).

Both Moses and Jesus were imagined to be philosophers in the ancient sense of the word.

“Philosophy in the ancient Greek and Roman world was not primarily theory ... it was a way of life, a way of being in the world. This was rooted in a way of seeing and understanding what the world really is. Philosophers did ponder big and mysterious ideas (the nature of matter and time), but this exploration was always for the purpose of helping people live a certain way ... based on knowing and loving what is truly Good. This is called ‘virtue’ and is all about the development of habits and character that correspond to reality so that one can enter into the fullness of human potential and flourishing, to become fully human.”

Pennington, Jonathan (2020). [Jesus the Great Philosopher](#). Brazos Press. 21-22, 28.

In the 1st century, *philosophia* (love of wisdom) was done in small social groups that gathered around a specific teacher who recruited a community of disciples. These communities were grounded in the body of teaching (*philosophia*) and a community practice, a shared way of life. All of it was focused on shaping one’s life toward the good—one’s thoughts, choices, habits, community, and vocation.

This tradition has been called “Virtue Ethics.”

- The Good Life and Human Flourishing: There is an ideal form of human life (moral choices being just one part) that leads to the most flourishing (Greek: *eudaimonia*).
- Character and Virtue: The focus of education is on a person’s moral character more than teaching a philosophy for making individual moral decisions. It’s about becoming a person who is virtuous, whose life is aligned in the direction of flourishing, not just a person who does the right thing.
- Communal and Formative: These ideal forms of human life that lead to flourishing are primarily communal and cannot be achieved merely on an individual, rational level.

The question driving Virtue Ethics is less “What should I do?” and more “What kind of person should I be?” and “With whom shall I become that kind of person?”

Jesus’ teaching and his way of arguing his points fit into this ancient tradition of moral and ethical teaching.

The sermon regularly touches on the flourishing life that results from following his teachings.

- “Blessing” and being among the happy or fortunate ([5:3-13](#))
- “Wholeness” that makes one like God ([5:48](#)).

- “Reward” that comes from integrity (6:1-18)
- An anxiety-free life (6:19-34)
- Production of “good fruit” (7:16-18)
- One’s life is like a house built on the rock (7:24-27)

The sermon focuses on people’s character and core motivations, in contrast to external, observable behavior which can be deceiving.

Matthew 5:8 Instructor's Translation

Blessed are the pure in heart, for they will see God.

Matthew 5:21-22 Instructor's Translation

You have heard it said, “Do not murder,” ... and I say to you, everyone who is angry at another is guilty ...

Matthew 5:27-28 Instructor's Translation

You have heard it said, “Don’t commit adultery;” but I say to you, anyone who looks at a woman so he can lust for her has already committed adultery.

Matthew 6:1 Instructor's Translation

Beware of doing your acts of righteousness before people so you can be noticed by them.

Matthew 6:21 Instructor's Translation

Where your wealth is, there your heart will be too.

This is why “hypocrisy” in the sermon does NOT mean “doing the opposite of what you say.” Rather, it means “doing the right thing for the wrong motives.” This sermon comes in the context of Jesus’ mission to form “Kingdom of God communities” in Galilee. He is creating “communities of virtue-formation,” not just lecturing on ethics in the abstract.

The sermon represents a Kingdom of God virtue ethic, in which Jesus argues that the kind of people who live by his ethical wisdom will be the ones who truly flourish as the world is transformed into the new creation.

A Biblical-Theology Approach to the Sermon

When we view the sermon in the context of the unified biblical story, in continuity with what has come before, we get some new perspective. Jesus calls what has come before “the Torah and the Prophets,” his phrase for the Hebrew Scriptures.

The Sermon as Torah

In the sermon, Jesus says he is “fulfilling the Torah and Prophets,” and he speaks these words claiming the authority of Israel’s God.

Matthew 5:17 Instructor's Translation

Don't suppose that I have come to do away with the **Torah or the Prophets**. I have not come to do away, **but to fill them full**.

Matthew 5:21-48 Instructor's Translation

You have heard it said + "Quotes from the Torah" + and **I** say to you ...

Matthew 7:12 Instructor's Translation

So then, everything you desire that people to do to you, so also you do to them; for this **is the Torah and the Prophets**.

Matthew 7:28-29 Instructor's Translation

When Jesus had finished these words, the crowds were amazed at his teaching; for he was teaching them as one having authority, and not as their scribes.

Jesus is presented as a new Moses, teaching a renewed *torah* for the people of God. People are not shocked that Jesus is teaching something foreign or new. They are amazed that he is assuming to have the same divine authority as the God of Israel, summoning Israel to allegiance to him as the way to be faithful to Israel's God.

Jesus presents the sermon as a revelation of God's will for his people to actually live by, not as an unattainable ideal.

The Sermon as Prophetic

Jesus' main message, summarized a few sentences before the sermon begins, is "the Kingdom of God has come near" (Matt. 4:17).

The reign of God was breaking into our world, Heaven was invading Earth, and the sermon represents a view of human relationships and of the world order that aligns itself with the values of this new order. The restorative reign of God, announced by Jesus, was the fulfillment of Moses and the prophets' anticipation of a "new covenant" where God's will, revealed in the Torah, would be "written on the hearts" of his people.

Deuteronomy 30:1-6 LEB

- ¹ And then when all of these things come upon you,
the blessing and the curse that I have set before you
and you call them to mind among the nations there where Yahweh your God has scattered you,
² and you return to Yahweh and you listen to his voice according to all that I am commanding you today,
both you and your children, with all your heart and with all your inner self,
³ and Yahweh your God will restore your fortunes, and he will have compassion upon you, and he will again
gather you together from all the peoples where Yahweh your God scattered you there. ...
⁶ **And Yahweh your God will circumcise your heart** and the heart of your offspring
to love Yahweh your God with all your heart and with all your inner self so that you may live.

Jeremiah 31:31-34 Instructor's Translation

"The days are coming," declares the Lord, "when I will make a new covenant with the people of Israel and with the people of Judah. It will not be like the covenant I made with their ancestors when I took them by

the hand to lead them out of Egypt, because they broke my covenant, though I was a husband to them,” declares the Lord.

“This is the covenant I will make with the people of Israel after that time,” declares the Lord. **“I will put my Torah in their minds and write it on their hearts.** I will be their God, and they will be my people. No longer will they teach their neighbor, or say to one another, ‘Know the Lord,’ because they will all know me, from the least of them to the greatest,” declares the Lord. “For I will forgive their wickedness and will remember their sins no more.”

Ezekiel 36:26–27 NIV

I will give you a new heart and put a new spirit in you; I will remove from you your heart of stone and give you a heart of flesh. And **I will put my Spirit in you and move you to follow my decrees** and be careful to keep my laws.

This is what Jesus means when he says his interpretation of covenant faithfulness “fulfills the Torah and the Prophets” (Matt. 5:17). To live by the ethics of the sermon is to live the life of the new covenant, empowered by God’s Spirit. It means experiencing a bit of new creation, now and here, in anticipation of the final setting right of all things.

The Sermon as Wisdom

Jesus presents his teachings as the true voice of Lady Wisdom from the book of Proverbs, offering the way to “the good life,” also known as the way to “blessing” (the “blessings/beatitudes” in 5:3-11). Jesus takes up the roles of Solomon as the fount of divine wisdom for Israel and of Lady Wisdom (both found in Proverbs 1-9), forcing his generation to make a decision.

Proverbs 3:33–35 (NASB95)

The curse of the LORD is on the house of the wicked,
but he blesses the dwelling of the righteous.
Though he scoffs at the scoffers,
yet he gives grace to the afflicted.
The wise will inherit honor,
but fools display dishonor.

Matthew 7:13–14 (NASB95)

Enter through the narrow gate; for the gate is wide and the way is broad that leads to destruction, and there are many who enter through it.
For the gate is small and the way is narrow that leads to life, and there are few who find it.

Proverbs 1:7 (NASB95)

The fear of the LORD is the beginning of knowledge;
fools despise wisdom and instruction.

Matthew 7:24–27 (NASB95)

Therefore everyone who hears these words of mine and acts on them, may be compared to a wise man who built his house on the rock.
And the rain fell, and the floods came, and the winds blew and slammed against that house; and yet it did not fall, for it had been founded on the rock.
Everyone who hears these words of mine and does

Proverbs 4:10–11 (NASB95)

Hear, my son, and accept my sayings
and the years of your life will be many.

Jesus’ Teaching as Lady Wisdom. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

I have directed you in **the way of wisdom;**
I have led you in upright paths.

Proverbs 8:35–36 (NASB95)

For he who finds me **finds life**
and obtains favor from the LORD.
But he who sins against me injures himself;
all those who hate me **love death.**

not act on them, will be like a **foolish man who**
built his house on the sand.

The rain fell, and the floods came, and the winds
blew and slammed against that house; and it fell—
and great was its fall.

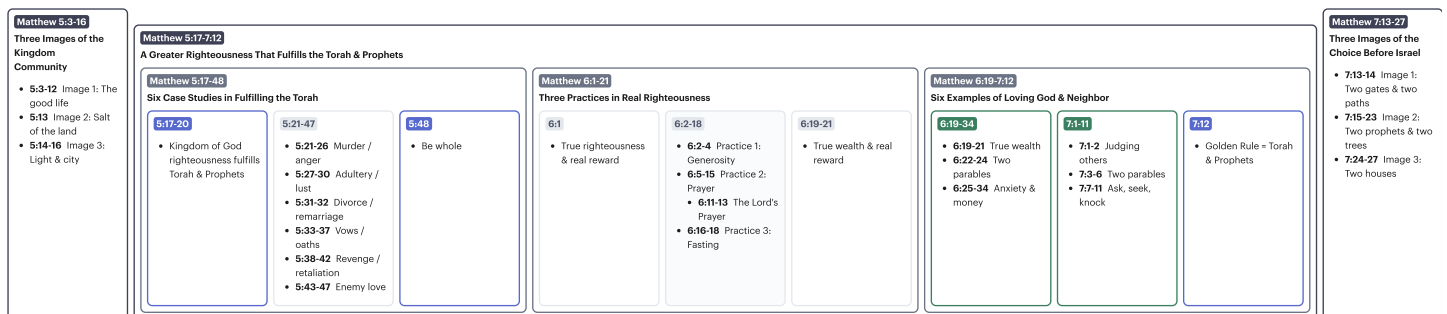
Jesus' Teaching as Lady Wisdom. Created by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Wisdom literature is an evidence-based worldview. It tells us that living in the fear of the Lord is true wisdom and will lead to a life of flourishing. Jesus is claiming that, counterintuitive as it may be, following his way of fulfilling the Torah and Prophets is the real and only way to flourish.

Jesus' Sermon Is Messianic Torah-Wisdom

Jesus reveals the divine ideal for living as God's covenant partners (*torah*/instruction) as he inaugurates the Kingdom of God here on Earth as in Heaven (messianic/prophetic), teaching true wisdom that leads to blessing and life (wisdom).

The Literary Design of the Sermon on the Mount



Matthew 5:3-7:27. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Matthew 5:3-16

Three Images of the Kingdom People

- **5:3-12** The nine-fold good life
- **5:13** Salt of the land
- **5:14-16** Light and city on the hill

Matthew 5:17-7:12

The Greater Righteousness as It Relates to ...

5:17-48

The Torah

A - **5:17-20** The greater **righteousness** that fulfills **the Torah and Prophets**

B - **5:21-47** **Six case studies** in the greater **righteousness**

- **5:21-26** Murder / anger
- **5:27-30** Adultery / lust
- **5:31-32** Divorce / remarriage
- **5:33-37** Vows / oaths
- **5:38-42** Revenge / retaliation
- **5:43-47** Enemy love

A' - **5:48** Be whole-complete

6:1-21

Devotion

A - **6:1** **True righteousness** and real reward

B - **6:2-18** **Three case studies** in genuine devotion

a - **6:2-4** Generosity to the poor

b - **6:5-15** Prayer (**v. 9b-13—The Lord's Prayer: "May your desire be done"**)

a' - **6:16-18** Fasting for God

A' - **6:19-21** True wealth and real reward

6:19-7:12

God and Neighbor

- **6:19-34** Allegiance, wealth, and worry

A - **6:19-21** Allegiance to God or wealth

B - **6:22-24** Two parables: The good & bad eye / Incompatibles: God vs. money

C - **6:25-34** Wealth and worry

- **7:1-11** Loving God and neighbor

A' - **7:1-2** Condemning others

B' - **7:3-6** Two Parables: Beam in the eye / Incompatibles: holy/pearls vs. dogs/pigs

C' - **7:7-11** Asking God

- **7:12** Whatever you **desire** others to do to you, do that to them. This is **the Torah and Prophets.**

Matthew 7:13-27

Three Images of the Choice Before Israel

- **7:13-14** Two gates & paths
- **7:15-23** Two trees & prophets

- **7:24-27** Two houses: on the rock or on the sand

Matthew 5:3-7:27 - Vertical. Translation and Literary Design by Tim Mackie for BibleProject Classroom: The Messianic Torah (2024).

Reflection Question

How did you first encounter the words of Jesus? In what ways were your first experiences with and understandings of Jesus' teachings similar to or different from those of Matthew's ancient audience?